

THE FAMILY EMERGENCY BINDER

Everything They'll Need

What my family would need to know, all in one place.

THIS BINDER BELONGS TO

LAST FULL REVIEW

IF FOUND, PLEASE CALL

INSIDE

- About me and my people
- Health
- Important documents
- Money
- Home and property
- Digital life
- People and pets who count on me
- Final wishes
- In my own words
- For my family
- Keeping it current

Private and confidential. Keep this binder somewhere safe, and tell two people where it is.

BEFORE YOU RELY ON THIS BOOK

For general information and planning only. This is not legal, tax, financial, medical or other professional advice, and using it doesn't create a professional relationship. Results are estimates based on the numbers you enter. Figures were checked on October 6, 2026 and can change. See the Terms of Use page before you rely on anything here.

This is an organizer, not a legal document. It is not a will, trust, power of attorney, health care directive or beneficiary form, and filling it in has no legal effect. Laws vary by state. Talk to an estate planning attorney about the documents you need. It will hold sensitive information: store it somewhere secure and share it only with people you trust.

How to use this book

This page is for you, the person filling it in. The rest of the binder is written so your family can follow it on a hard day.

1 Start with page 4 and your key contacts on page 7.

The Start Here page and your key contacts take about 30 minutes, and they cover most of what your family would need in the first week. If you only do one thing this month, do those.

2 Write in pencil, or in pen with a correction plan.

Every line in this book is spaced for handwriting. Pencil makes updates easy. If you'd rather type and reprint pages, the fillable digital version is at the ProofNotFluff shop on Etsy. Every page has a Page updated date in the footer, so your family can see how current each page is.

3 Write where things are, not the secrets themselves.

Don't write full passwords, full account numbers or your Social Security number here. Write the bank and the last 4 digits, and where the password or card is kept. A lost binder should not be a gift to a thief.

4 Store it somewhere safe.

A fireproof box at home is better than a bank safe deposit box. A box in only your name can be hard for family to open quickly after a death. If you keep a digital copy or photos of these pages, keep them somewhere protected, like an encrypted drive or a password manager's secure file storage. Don't email them to yourself.

5 Tell two people where it is.

A binder nobody can find doesn't help anyone. Tell your executor and one other person you trust. The wallet card on page 39 helps.

6 Look at it once a year.

Pick a date you won't miss, like your birthday or when you do your taxes. The checklist on page 38 takes about 20 minutes.

Your progress

☐ About me

☐ Money

☐ Kids and pets

☐ For family

☐ Health

☐ Home

☐ Wishes

☐ Updates

☐ Documents

☐ Digital

☐ My words

GOOD TO KNOW

This binder is an organizer, not a legal document. It doesn't replace a will, a trust, a power of attorney or a health care directive. It tells your family where those are and what you want. If you don't have those documents yet, the Documents section shows which ones most people need, so you know what to ask an attorney about.

NOTES

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Each section's name sits at the top of its pages, and every page has a Page updated line in the footer.

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KEEPING IT CURRENT

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Start here

If you're reading this, something has happened to me. Take a breath. You don't have to do everything today. This page tells you who to call and where things are. The pages after it fill in the rest.

THIS BINDER WAS WRITTEN FOR

WRITTEN BY

Call these people first

NAME	RELATIONSHIP	PHONE	WHY CALL THEM

Where the important things are

WHAT	WHERE IT IS, OR WHO HAS IT
My will and other legal papers	
This binder's digital file, if any	
Password manager emergency access	
My phone passcode	
Spare house and car keys	
Fireproof box or safe, and its key or code	
Cash kept at home	
Pet care instructions	

Then go to the page that fits

If I'm in the hospital or can't speak for myself

Who decides, what to bring, and which bills to keep paying.
Page 33

If I have died

What to do in the first 72 hours, the first month, and the first year. Page 34

About me

The basic facts your family will be asked for again and again: by the hospital, the funeral home, the bank and the court.

FULL LEGAL NAME		OTHER NAMES USED (MAIDEN, NICKNAMES)
DATE OF BIRTH	PLACE OF BIRTH (CITY, STATE)	CITIZENSHIP
HOME ADDRESS		PHONE
EMAIL	SSN: LAST 4 ONLY	WHERE THE CARD IS KEPT
DRIVER'S LICENSE: STATE AND WHERE KEPT		PASSPORT: WHERE KEPT

Family status

MARITAL STATUS		SINCE (YEAR)
☐ Single ☐ Married ☐ Partnered ☐ Divorced ☐ Widowed		
SPOUSE OR PARTNER'S NAME	DATE MARRIED	WHERE THE MARRIAGE CERTIFICATE IS
FORMER SPOUSE(S) AND DIVORCE YEAR		WHERE THE DIVORCE DECREE IS

Work and service

EMPLOYER OR FORMER EMPLOYER	JOB TITLE	HR OR BENEFITS PHONE
RETIRED FROM	PENSION OR RETIREE BENEFITS CONTACT	
MILITARY SERVICE	BRANCH, YEARS, AND WHERE YOUR DD-214 IS KEPT	
☐ No ☐ Yes		
FAITH COMMUNITY, IF ANY	CLUBS, UNIONS OR GROUPS THAT SHOULD BE TOLD	

For the death certificate

FATHER'S FULL NAME AND BIRTHPLACE	MOTHER'S FULL NAME (INCL. MAIDEN) AND BIRTHPLACE
HIGHEST LEVEL OF EDUCATION	USUAL OCCUPATION AND INDUSTRY

GOOD TO KNOW

Veterans may be eligible for burial in a national cemetery, a headstone or marker, and a burial allowance. The family will need the discharge papers (form DD-214) to apply, which is why it's worth knowing exactly where yours is.

Anything helpful to know: someone who should hear the news in person, a relative who isn't in touch, someone who will need extra support.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Key contacts

The people with a job to do. If a role doesn't apply, leave it blank.

ROLE	NAME	PHONE	EMAIL OR NOTES
Executor (named in my will)			
Backup executor			
Health care agent			
Financial power of attorney			
Attorney			
Accountant or tax preparer			
Financial advisor			
Insurance agent			
Primary doctor			
Employer HR or benefits			
Clergy or spiritual contact			
Neighbor with a key			
Landlord, HOA or property manager			
Someone who knows my computer			
Other			
Other			

GOOD TO KNOW

Ask the people you name before you name them, and tell them where this binder is. An executor or health care agent who hears about the job for the first time in an emergency starts from behind.

Medical information

What a doctor or EMT would ask, written down so nobody has to guess.

PRIMARY DOCTOR

PHONE

PREFERRED HOSPITAL

PHARMACY AND PHONE

BLOOD TYPE

HEALTH INSURANCE OR MEDICARE PLAN

WHERE MY INSURANCE CARDS ARE

MEDIGAP, PART D OR SUPPLEMENTAL PLAN

Medications

MEDICATION	DOSE	WHEN I TAKE IT	WHAT IT'S FOR	PRESCRIBED BY

Specialists

DOCTOR	SPECIALTY	PHONE	CLINIC OR HOSPITAL

ALLERGIES AND REACTIONS

CONDITIONS AND PAST SURGERIES

ORGAN AND TISSUE DONOR

REGISTERED WHERE (LICENSE, STATE REGISTRY)

☐ Yes
☐ No
☐ Undecided

DOCUMENT	HAVE IT	DATE SIGNED	WHERE THE ORIGINAL IS	WHO HAS A COPY
Advance directive or living will	☐			
Health care power of attorney (or proxy)	☐			
HIPAA release	☐			
POLST, MOLST or DNR order	☐			
Long-term care insurance policy	☐			

[illegible]

Your directive covers the legal part. This is the human part: what a good day looks like for you, what you'd want to avoid, and what your agent should keep in mind if it comes to a hard choice. It isn't an advance directive and has no legal effect; it's notes for the people you've named.

Hospitals need to see your directive and agent document, and the originals are often locked in a drawer when the call comes. Give your agent and your doctor copies now. Some states also run an advance directive registry. A HIPAA release lets doctors talk to the people you name, even if they aren't your agent.

Where my documents are

Finding papers is one of the hardest jobs for a family. Check what you have, and say exactly where the original is.

DOCUMENT	HAVE IT	WHERE THE ORIGINAL IS	WHO HAS A COPY
Will	☐		
Trust	☐		
Financial power of attorney	☐		
Birth certificate	☐		
Marriage certificate	☐		
Divorce papers	☐		
Social Security card	☐		
Passport	☐		
Military discharge (DD-214)	☐		
Property deeds	☐		
Vehicle titles	☐		
Life insurance policies	☐		
Last 3 years of tax returns	☐		
Prenup or postnup	☐		
Pre-paid funeral or cemetery contract	☐		
Adoption or citizenship papers	☐		
Business agreements	☐		
Other	☐		

GOOD TO KNOW

If you keep originals in a bank safe deposit box, add a co-owner or check what your bank and state allow after a death. In some cases the family needs a court order to open a box held in one name, and the will might be inside it.

- ☐ **Will** Says who gets what and names your executor. If you have minor children, it's also where you name a guardian. Without one, state law decides.
- ☐ **Financial power of attorney** Lets someone you choose handle money and paperwork if you can't. Without one, your family may have to go to court for a guardianship or conservatorship.
- ☐ **Health care power of attorney** Names the person who makes medical decisions when you can't speak for yourself. Sometimes called a health care proxy.
- ☐ **Advance directive or living will** Puts your wishes for end-of-life care in writing, so your agent isn't guessing.

ANYTHING I STILL NEED TO DO

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

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MAIN BANK I USE

HOW MOST BILLS GET PAID (AUTOPAY, ONLINE, CHECKS)

WHERE STATEMENTS GO (PAPER, WHICH EMAIL)

WHO HELPS ME WITH MONEY

SOURCE	PAID INTO (BANK, LAST 4)	ABOUT HOW MUCH	HOW OFTEN	WHO TO CALL

If I can't manage my money for a while

- ## BILLS AND DEADLINES THAT CAN'T SLIP

While you're alive, only your agent under a financial power of attorney (or a joint owner, for a joint account) should use your accounts. Once you die, that power ends, and your executor takes over after the court appoints them. Family should not keep using your cards or accounts during that gap. Mortgage, insurance and utility bills still need paying, so the executor should ask the estate attorney how to keep them current.

Bank accounts

Checking, savings, money market, CDs and credit union accounts. Last 4 digits only.

BANK OR CREDIT UNION	TYPE	LAST 4	OWNER: ME, JOINT (WITH WHOM)	POD BENEFICIARY

WHERE MY ONLINE LOGINS ARE KEPT

BRANCH OR BANKER I DEAL WITH

Cash, checks and cards

WHERE MY CHECKBOOK IS

CASH AT HOME AND WHERE

DEBIT AND CREDIT CARDS: WHERE

GOOD TO KNOW

Joint accounts usually go straight to the surviving owner. Payable-on-death (POD) accounts go to the person named with the bank. Neither follows your will. That's often helpful, since it skips probate, but it can also undo a plan by accident. If your will splits things evenly among your children and one child is the joint owner on your main account, that account may go to that child alone.

WHERE STATEMENTS AND LOGINS ARE

Stock options, RSUs, deferred pay or a pension

Your beneficiary form beats your will. Retirement accounts, life insurance, annuities and HSAs go to whoever is named on the company's beneficiary form, even if your will says something different. One exception: in most workplace plans like a 401(k) or 403(b), federal law makes your spouse the beneficiary unless they signed a written waiver, so check the plan's form after a marriage or divorce. The most common mistakes: an ex-spouse still listed, no backup (contingent) beneficiary, a minor child named directly, and "my estate" listed, which can pull the account into probate. The next page is a quick check-up.

Beneficiary check-up

Log in to each account or call, and confirm who's named. It takes about an hour, and it can prevent the most expensive mistakes.

ACCOUNT	PRIMARY	BACKUP (CONTINGENT)	CONFIRMED ON	OK
Life insurance (my own policy)				☐
Life insurance through work				☐
401(k) or 403(b)				☐
Old 401(k) from a past job				☐
IRA or Roth IRA				☐
HSA				☐
Annuity				☐
Pension survivor option				☐
Bank accounts (POD)				☐
Brokerage account (TOD)				☐
Home (transfer-on-death deed, where allowed)				☐
Vehicle (TOD title, where allowed)				☐

Check for these

- ☐ No ex-spouse is still named anywhere, unless that's on purpose.
- ☐ Every account has a backup beneficiary, not just a primary.
- ☐ No minor child is named directly. Ask the company or an attorney about a custodian or a trust.
- ☐ Someone who gets needs-based benefits, like SSI or Medicaid, isn't named directly in a way that could affect them.
- ☐ The names on these forms match what my will says I want.

Insurance

Every policy, including the ones that come with a job, a credit card or a membership. Families often miss these.

TYPE	COMPANY	POLICY # (LAST 4) AND WHERE	AGENT OR PHONE	BENEFICIARY OR NOTES
Life insurance				
Life insurance through work				
Accidental death (AD&D)				
Health				
Medicare supplement or Advantage				
Long-term care				
Disability				
Homeowners or renters				
Auto				
Umbrella				
Pet				
Other				

GOOD TO KNOW

Life insurance through work is often worth one or two times salary, and people forget they have it. Some credit cards and travel bookings include accidental death coverage too. Ask your HR team for a benefits summary and keep it with this binder.

GOOD TO KNOW

If a home will sit empty after a death, tell the homeowners insurer right away. Many policies limit coverage on a vacant home, and a burst pipe in an empty house is expensive.

Debts and credit cards

What's owed, so your executor can pay what's real and spot anything that isn't.

DEBT	LENDER	LAST 4	PAID FROM (AUTOPAY?)	CO-SIGNER OR JOINT?	NOTES
Mortgage					
Home equity loan or HELOC					
Car loan					
Student loans					
Personal loan					
Credit card					
Credit card					
Credit card					
Credit card					
Medical bills					
Other					

Money owed to me

WHO OWES IT	ABOUT HOW MUCH	PAPERWORK OR TERMS

GOOD TO KNOW

In general, family members don't inherit your debts. Your estate pays valid debts before anything is passed on. The exceptions are people who co-signed or own the account jointly, and spouses in some states. Federal student loans are discharged when the borrower dies, once the servicer gets a death certificate. Your family should never pay a debt out of their own pocket before talking to the executor.

[illegible]

Ideas: phone, streaming, software, gym, memberships, newspapers, meal kits, cloud storage, donations, charities, app subscriptions billed through Apple or Google.

Taxes, business and rentals

The things that keep running on a schedule, even when nobody's watching.

TAX PREPARER AND PHONE

WHERE PAST RETURNS ARE KEPT

DO I PAY ESTIMATED TAXES?

STATE(S) I FILE IN

TAX SOFTWARE LOGIN KEPT WHERE

Businesses I own or am part of

BUSINESS	MY ROLE AND SHARE	PARTNERS OR KEY PERSON	AGREEMENT KEPT WHERE

WHO SHOULD KEEP IT RUNNING, WIND IT DOWN, OR BE CALLED FIRST

Rental property

PROPERTY	LONG OR SHORT-TERM	MANAGER OR CO-HOST	BOOKING SITES AND LOGINS

GOOD TO KNOW

Short-term rentals keep taking bookings on their own. If you host, write down who can message guests, change door codes and pause the calendar. Upcoming guests and cleaners will need someone quickly.

Money that's easy to miss

Check each one you have, and say where to find it. These are the accounts families most often find months later, or never.

☐ Old 401(k)s and pensions from past jobs

☐ Health savings account (HSA)

☐ Life insurance through work or a union

☐ Accidental death coverage on credit cards

☐ U.S. savings bonds (paper or TreasuryDirect)

☐ Annuities

☐ Stock options, RSUs or deferred pay

☐ Cryptocurrency (where the wallet and recovery info are)

☐ PayPal, Venmo or Cash App balances

☐ Airline miles, hotel points, credit card rewards

☐ Gift cards and store credit

☐ Security deposits (rent, utilities)

☐ Money people owe me

☐ Refunds, rebates or a pending tax refund

☐ Safe deposit box

☐ Benefits from a club, union or fraternal group

ANYTHING ELSE ONLY I KNOW ABOUT

GOOD TO KNOW

Every state keeps a list of unclaimed money. Your family can search most states at once at missingmoney.com, and find every state's official site at unclaimed.org. A surviving spouse or child may also qualify for a one-time \$255 Social Security death payment and monthly survivor benefits. They should ask Social Security directly. (Social Security Administration, ssa.gov, checked October 6, 2026.)

ADDRESS

OWN OR RENT

HOA OR PROPERTY MANAGER

HOMEOWNERS INSURER

ALARM COMPANY AND PHONE

WI-FI NETWORK

ELECTRICAL PANEL

SUMP PUMP OR WELL

THINGS THAT NEED REGULAR CARE (POOL, PLANTS, FILTERS)

- ☐ Keep valuables, documents and spare keys locked away.

[illegible]

Utilities and home services

Who to call, and how each one is paid. Account numbers: last 4 only.

SERVICE	COMPANY	ACCT LAST 4	PAID HOW	PHONE
Electric				
Gas or propane				
Water and sewer				
Trash				
Internet				
Home phone				
Cell phone				
Alarm or security				
Lawn or snow				
Cleaning				
Heating and cooling service				
Plumber				
Electrician				
Handyman				
Pest control				
Other				
Other				

Vehicles, property and valuables

Anything with a title, a key, or a story.

Vehicles

YEAR, MAKE, MODEL	TITLE IS WHERE	LOAN WITH	SPARE KEY	INSURER

Other property

Storage units, land, a cabin, a boat, a timeshare, a cemetery plot, firearms (and where they're secured).

WHAT	WHERE	PAPERWORK, KEYS OR ACCESS

Valuables and things that matter

ITEM	WHERE IT IS	WHO I'D LIKE TO HAVE IT	THE STORY, IF THERE IS ONE

GOOD TO KNOW

This list tells your family what you'd like. It may not be binding on its own. Many states let a will refer to a separate list of personal items, so ask your attorney how to make this list count.

Getting into my devices

Most of life now sits behind a passcode. Without a way in, a family can lose photos, bills and accounts for good.

DON'T WRITE PASSWORDS HERE

Use a password manager and turn on its emergency access feature, then write down which one you use and who your emergency contact is. If you don't use one, keep a sealed envelope with your phone passcode and main passwords somewhere secure, and write down where it is.

PASSWORD MANAGER I USE

EMERGENCY ACCESS SET UP FOR

WHERE MY MASTER PASSWORD OR RECOVERY KIT IS

WHO KNOWS

Phone and computers

DEVICE	PASSCODE IS KEPT WHERE	BACKED UP TO	NOTES

Legacy settings

- ☐ Apple Legacy Contact set up (Settings, your name, Sign-In and Security).
- ☐ Google Inactive Account Manager set up (in your Google Account, under Data and privacy).
- ☐ Facebook legacy contact chosen, or I've asked for my account to be deleted.
- ☐ Backup codes for two-step sign-in are printed and stored with this binder's secure copy.

PHONE NUMBER USED FOR SIGN-IN CODES

CARRIER AND WHO SHOULD KEEP THE NUMBER ACTIVE

GOOD TO KNOW

Keep the phone line active for a few months after a death. Many accounts send sign-in codes by text, and losing the number can lock your family out of everything else.

Email, accounts and wishes

Usernames and what you'd like done. Not passwords.

Email accounts

EMAIL ADDRESS	USED FOR	RECOVERY PHONE OR EMAIL

Online accounts

SERVICE	USERNAME OR EMAIL	KEEP	CLOSE	MEMORIALIZE	NOTES (DOWNLOAD PHOTOS FIRST, ETC.)
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	
		☐	☐	☐	

WHERE MY PHOTOS AND VIDEOS ARE STORED

WHO SHOULD GET COPIES

WEBSITES, DOMAINS OR ONLINE SHOPS I OWN

RENEWAL DATES AND WHERE THEY'RE PAID FROM

Children and dependents

What a guardian or caregiver would need on the first day. Your will is where a guardian is legally named. This page is the everyday part.

GUARDIAN NAMED IN MY WILL

BACKUP GUARDIAN

Child or dependent 1

NAME

DATE OF BIRTH

SCHOOL OR PROGRAM

DOCTOR AND PHONE

ALLERGIES AND MEDICATIONS

PEOPLE THEY TRUST

ACTIVITIES AND SCHEDULE

ROUTINES, COMFORT AND WHAT HELPS ON A HARD DAY

Child or dependent 2

NAME

DATE OF BIRTH

SCHOOL OR PROGRAM

DOCTOR AND PHONE

ALLERGIES AND MEDICATIONS

PEOPLE THEY TRUST

ACTIVITIES AND SCHEDULE

ROUTINES, COMFORT AND WHAT HELPS ON A HARD DAY

NOTES

GOOD TO KNOW

If you care for an adult, like a parent or a family member with a disability, use this page for them too. Write down their doctors, benefits, and the people who help, so care doesn't stop if you can't be there.

Pets

Pets can't tell anyone what they need. These two cards make sure someone knows.

Pet 1

NAME	KIND AND BREED	AGE	MICROCHIP COMPANY AND #
VET AND PHONE	MEDICATIONS	PET INSURANCE	
FOOD, AMOUNT AND WHEN	WALKS, HABITS, FEARS		
WHO SHOULD CARE FOR THEM	BACKUP	SUPPLIES AND RECORDS ARE WHERE	
GROOMER, SITTER OR DAYCARE	WHERE THEY GO IF NO ONE CAN TAKE THEM		

Pet 2

NAME	KIND AND BREED	AGE	MICROCHIP COMPANY AND #
VET AND PHONE	MEDICATIONS	PET INSURANCE	
FOOD, AMOUNT AND WHEN	WALKS, HABITS, FEARS		
WHO SHOULD CARE FOR THEM	BACKUP	SUPPLIES AND RECORDS ARE WHERE	
GROOMER, SITTER OR DAYCARE	WHERE THEY GO IF NO ONE CAN TAKE THEM		

ANYTHING ELSE THEY'D WANT YOU TO KNOW

GOOD TO KNOW

Ask your caregiver first, and consider leaving money for the pet's care. Every state allows a pet trust, and your attorney can tell you whether it makes sense for you.

Final wishes

Your family will want to get this right. Telling them what you want is a gift, even if your answer is "whatever is easiest for you."

I'D LIKE

☐ Burial ☐ Cremation ☐ Green burial ☐ Body donation ☐ Let my family decide

FUNERAL HOME I'D PREFER

PRE-PAID PLAN OR CONTRACT AND WHERE

CEMETERY OR WHERE MY ASHES GO

PLOT OR DEED DETAILS

FOR A GATHERING

☐ Funeral ☐ Memorial service ☐ Celebration of life ☐ Private family only ☐ Nothing formal

WHERE

WHO SHOULD LEAD IT

RELIGIOUS OR NOT

MUSIC, READINGS OR POEMS

PEOPLE I'D LIKE TO SPEAK

FLOWERS, OR DONATIONS INSTEAD TO

WHAT PEOPLE SHOULD WEAR

ANYTHING ELSE: WHAT I'D LOVE, AND WHAT I'D RATHER SKIP

GOOD TO KNOW

Wishes written here aren't legally binding in most places, and in some states the right to decide belongs to a person you name in a separate form. Ask your attorney or funeral home what your state uses. A pre-paid plan helps, but read what it covers: many cover the funeral home's services but not the cemetery.

FINAL WISHES

For my obituary

The facts people scramble to find. Write as much or as little as you like.

FULL NAME AS I'D LIKE IT WRITTEN

NICKNAME

PHOTO TO USE: WHERE

BORN (DATE AND PLACE)

GREW UP IN

SCHOOLS

WORK AND CAREER

FAMILY TO NAME (SURVIVED BY, AND PRECEDED BY)

WHAT I'D WANT PEOPLE TO KNOW ABOUT MY LIFE

WHERE IT SHOULD APPEAR (PAPER, WEBSITE)

WHO SHOULD WRITE IT

GOOD TO KNOW

Leave the exact home address out of the obituary and social posts, and have someone stay at the house during the service. Empty homes during funerals are a known target for break-ins.

People to tell

Friends, colleagues and groups who should hear the news. Your family can tick each one off.

NAME OR GROUP	HOW THEY KNOW ME	PHONE OR EMAIL	TOLD
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
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			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

IN MY OWN WORDS

A few words from me

Not instructions. Just what you'd want them to hear. Write to one person or to everyone.

TO

DATE _____

[illegible]

IN MY OWN WORDS

A few more words

TO

DATE _____

If I'm in the hospital

Or can't speak for myself for a while. You're not deciding everything at once. Start at the top.

Right away

- ☐ Call my health care agent (Key Contacts page). They make medical decisions if I can't.
- ☐ Bring copies of my advance directive and health care power of attorney, my medication list, and my insurance cards. The Health pages say where they are.
- ☐ Tell the care team about allergies and medications (Medical Information page).
- ☐ Make sure someone is looking after children, pets and the house (Kids and Pets pages).
- ☐ Ask for the hospital social worker or case manager. They help with insurance, discharge planning and next steps.

In the first week

- ☐ The agent named in my financial power of attorney takes over the bills. Nobody else should use my cards or accounts.
- ☐ Keep paying what can't slip: mortgage or rent, insurance, utilities, car loan (Money at a Glance).
- ☐ Tell my employer, and ask HR about sick leave, short-term disability and FMLA paperwork.
- ☐ Hold the mail, stop deliveries, and check the house every few days.
- ☐ Keep a notebook: doctors' names, what they said, questions, dates. It helps more than you'd think.

If it goes on for a while

- ☐ Look at disability and long-term care insurance (Insurance page). Claims often have waiting periods, so start early.
- ☐ Check which autopays to pause or cancel (Bills page).
- ☐ Ask the care team whether palliative care or hospice could help. Neither means giving up. Both focus on comfort.

Who's doing what

JOB	WHO	PHONE

After I die: the first 72 hours

Most things can wait. These can't. You don't need to know how probate works yet.

- ☐ **Get a legal pronouncement of death.** If I die at home under hospice care, call the hospice nurse, not 911. If it's unexpected, call 911.
- ☐ **If I wanted to be a donor,** tell the hospital or hospice right away (Medical Information page). The window is short.
- ☐ **Call the funeral home** (Final Wishes page). They'll transport me and guide you through the next steps.
- ☐ **Tell close family and my executor** (Start Here and Key Contacts pages).
- ☐ **Secure the house, car and pets.** Lock up, take valuables and spare keys somewhere safe, and make sure pets are fed.
- ☐ **Find the will and my final wishes.** Don't hand out belongings or money yet, even things I promised. The executor does that later.
- ☐ **Order death certificates through the funeral home.** Get more than you think you'll need. Banks, insurers and others each want a certified copy, and 6 to 10 is common.
- ☐ **Ask the funeral home to report the death to Social Security.** They usually do. Don't spend Social Security payments that arrive after the death. The payment for the month of death, and any after it, has to be returned (Social Security Administration, ssa.gov, checked October 6, 2026).
- ☐ **Tell my employer if I was working,** and ask about final pay, life insurance and benefits.
- ☐ **Rest. Eat something. Let people help.** Give them specific jobs: meals, calls, picking people up from the airport.

Who's doing what

JOB	WHO'S HANDLING IT	PHONE	DONE
Calling family and close friends			☐
Funeral home and arrangements			☐
Food, visitors and messages			☐
House, mail and pets			☐
Travel and airport pickups			☐
Paperwork and death certificates			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

GOOD TO KNOW

Keep a running list of every call you make: the date, who you spoke with, and what happens next. The Calls and Claims Log on page 37 is there for exactly that.

Legal and paperwork

- ## Tell these organizations

- ## Protect against fraud

- [illegible]

Keep the house insured, the heat on, and the essential bills paid. Close accounts slowly. An account that looks unneeded can be the one a pension or refund gets paid into.

The first year

Settling an estate usually takes months, sometimes longer. This is the usual order, as general information, not legal or tax advice (Terms of Use, page 41). Your attorney will tell you what applies in your state.

- 1

List everything
Use the Money and Home sections to make an inventory of what I owned and what I owed. Get values as of the date of death: statements for accounts, and an appraisal for real estate and valuable items.
- 2

Collect what's owed
File life insurance claims, roll over or claim retirement accounts, collect final pay, refunds and deposits, and check the Money That's Easy to Miss page.
- 3

Pay valid debts and bills
From the estate, not your own pocket. The attorney will tell you the order and the deadlines for creditors.
- 4

File the taxes
My final income tax return is due by the usual April deadline the year after I die. If the estate earns income while it's open, it may need its own return (Form 1041). A tax preparer is worth it here. (IRS Publication 559 and Form 1041 instructions, irs.gov, checked October 6, 2026.)
- 5

Transfer and distribute
Retitle the house and cars, transfer accounts, and give belongings and money as the will says. Get signed receipts from each person.
- 6

Close the estate
File the final accounting if the court requires it, close the estate account, and keep the records for several years.

Estate details

PROBATE COURT AND CASE NUMBER

ESTATE ATTORNEY AND PHONE

ESTATE EIN IS KEPT WHERE

ESTATE BANK ACCOUNT

NOTES

GOOD TO KNOW

Many inherited investments and homes get a new tax cost basis equal to their value on the date of death. That can sharply lower capital gains tax if they're sold later, but only if someone records those values. Ask the tax preparer before selling anything. (IRS, gifts and inheritances FAQ, irs.gov, checked October 6, 2026.)

[illegible]

Once a year

Twenty minutes, once a year. Pick a date you'll remember and put it on your calendar now.

MY YEARLY REVIEW DATE

CALENDAR REMINDER SET

COPIES OF THIS BINDER ARE WITH

The yearly check

- ☐ Contacts are current: phone numbers, my executor, my agents, my doctors.
- ☐ Medications and doctors are up to date.
- ☐ Beneficiaries still match my wishes (Beneficiary Check-up page).
- ☐ New or closed accounts are added or crossed off.
- ☐ Insurance policies and agents are current.
- ☐ Password manager emergency access still points to the right person.
- ☐ Final wishes and guardian choices still feel right.
- ☐ Any copies match this book, and the two people who know where it is still know.

Also update after

A marriage or divorce, a birth or adoption, a death in the family, a move, a new job or retirement, buying or selling a home, a new diagnosis, or opening or closing a major account.

Update log

DATE	WHAT CHANGED	COPIES UPDATED
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

Wallet card and door note

Fill in and cut out, or photocopy the page first. One card for your wallet, one for a partner or your executor. Put the note on the refrigerator door.

IN CASE OF EMERGENCY NAME _____ PLEASE CALL _____ THEIR PHONE _____ MY BINDER IS _____ <i>Allergies and medications are listed in my binder.</i>	IN CASE OF EMERGENCY NAME _____ PLEASE CALL _____ THEIR PHONE _____ MY BINDER IS _____ <i>Allergies and medications are listed in my binder.</i>
--	--

For emergency responders

INFORMATION FOR EMTS AND FIREFIGHTERS	
NAME _____	DATE OF BIRTH _____
MEDICAL CONDITIONS _____	
ALLERGIES _____	
DOCTOR AND PHONE _____	BLOOD TYPE _____
MEDICATIONS LIST IS KEPT _____	HEALTH CARE AGENT AND PHONE _____
DNR OR POLST: YES OR NO, AND WHERE _____	EMERGENCY CONTACT AND PHONE _____
PETS IN THE HOME _____	

Tip: many fire departments ask people to keep this note on the refrigerator, because that's where responders look.

You did something kind

Most people never get around to this. By filling in even part of this binder, you've taken a great deal of guesswork off the people you love, in one of the hardest weeks of their lives.

You don't have to finish it all at once. Come back to a section when you have twenty minutes. Every page you complete is one less thing someone has to search for.

Where I'm keeping things

THIS BOOK

COPIES OR DIGITAL FILE

PEOPLE WHO KNOW WHERE IT IS

NEXT REVIEW DATE

TERMS OF USE AND SOURCES

This is an organizer, not a legal document. It is not a will, trust, power of attorney, health care directive or beneficiary form, and filling it in has no legal effect. Laws vary by state. Talk to an estate planning attorney about the documents you need. It will hold sensitive information: store it somewhere secure and share it only with people you trust. It is general information, not legal, tax, financial, medical or other professional advice. The full Terms of Use and Disclaimer, and the sources and as-of date October 6, 2026 for every rule and figure in this binder, are on page 41. Read them before you rely on anything here.

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Thank you for doing this for them.



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NOTICE

For general information and planning only. This is not legal, tax, financial, medical or other professional advice, and using it doesn't create a professional relationship. Results are estimates based on the numbers you enter. Figures were checked on October 6, 2026 and can change. See the Terms of Use page before you rely on anything here.

This is an organizer, not a legal document. It is not a will, trust, power of attorney, health care directive or beneficiary form, and filling it in has no legal effect. Laws vary by state. Talk to an estate planning attorney about the documents you need. It will hold sensitive information: store it somewhere secure and share it only with people you trust.

SOURCES AND AS-OF DATE

Rules and figures in this binder were checked on October 6, 2026 against: Social Security Administration, ssa.gov (lump-sum death payment of \$255 to an eligible spouse or child, apply within 2 years; benefits aren't paid for the month of death; funeral homes usually report deaths); IRS Publication 559 and Form 1041 instructions, irs.gov (final return due date, estate income tax return, estate EIN, basis of inherited property); Federal Student Aid, studentaid.gov (federal student loan death discharge); U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs, va.gov (burial benefits and DD-214); U.S. Department of Labor, EBSA, dol.gov (spousal rights in workplace retirement plans); NAUPA, unclaimed.org and missingmoney.com (unclaimed property). State rules vary. Confirm current details with the agency before acting.

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Notes